

Story1

As the summer heat intensified, so did the frustration among the faculty at Reedwood University. They found themselves housed in a building with a critical waterproofing layer missing, a fact that had become abundantly clear as the southern rains poured in through the missing protection. The incessant dripping, the sodden carpets, and the lingering smell of mildew permeated every corner of the building. It was a tangible reminder of their collective distress.

Dr. Elizabeth Thompson, a professor of history, paced her office, her footsteps creating a syncopated rhythm with the dripping sounds from above. Her books – her precious research materials – were now nestled uncomfortably in plastic bins, their pages curling with dampness. The frown on her face deepened as she surveyed the room, its walls peeling and discoloring.

"How can they expect us to work like this?" she mumbled under her breath, sinking into her chair with defeat.

The construction repairs had promised relief, but instead, they brought only more disruption. Every morning, the faculty was greeted by the cacophony of drilling, hammering, and the constant movement of workers throughout the building. With each passing day, the promise of a quiet, focused academic environment seemed to drift further away.

Dr. Thompson entered the hallway, where her colleagues congregated, exchanging exasperated glances and sighs of resignation. Dr. Jonathan Miller, a physics professor, leaned against the wall, clutching a mug of lukewarm coffee.

"I can't even hear myself think," he grumbled, rubbing his temples.

"And the dust! It's everywhere!" added Dr. Sarah Morgan, a chemistry professor, her face a mask of frustration.

Amidst the chaos, tensions rose, patience wore thin, and soon tempers flared. The elevators, the sole respite from the stairs, were constantly out of order, leaving the faculty to trudge up and down numerous flights of stairs. The faculty lounge, where they sought solace and camaraderie, became overcrowded and uncomfortable. With each passing day, it seemed as if their shared space was shrinking, and with it, their patience.

But life at Reedwood continued to soldier on, despite the mounting inconveniences. Classes were held, research was conducted, and the faculty continued their pursuit of knowledge, albeit through gritted teeth. They clung to the hope that all this would be worth it in the end, that their perseverance would result in better future circumstances.

Months turned into a year, and soon, the construction noise faded away. The day arrived when the faculty could finally return to their offices, to a building restored, albeit with scars that told tales of their endurance. As they donned gloves and masks, scrubbing away the remnants of chaos, a sense of relief washed over them.

Dr. Thompson reclined in her newly renovated office, her books finally back on the shelves where they belonged. The sunlight streamed through the windows, unhindered by leaks or cracks. It was a quiet moment, a pause after the storm. She breathed in deeply and exhaled, letting go of the tension and the frustration that had plagued her for so long.

As the days passed, a newfound sense of resilience emerged among the faculty. Adversity had forged their collective spirit, and they were determined to make the most of their renewed circumstances. The disrupted academic year had left its mark, but it hadn't broken them. They had persevered, and in doing so, had found a strength they never knew they had.

They gathered in the faculty lounge, no longer feeling cramped and overwhelmed. The renovation had brought about an unexpected transformation in the space. The once crowded room now had more seating areas, a fresh coat of paint on the walls, and a display of photographs capturing the journey they had gone through together.

The faculty found comfort and solace in coming together, sharing their stories and experiences of the renovation period. Each tale resonated with others, creating a deep bond of understanding and empathy. They laughed, they cried, and they lifted each other up, knowing that they had truly overcome a great challenge.

Motivated by their shared ordeal, the faculty organized a celebration to commemorate the successful completion of the renovations. They invited the construction workers who had toiled tirelessly, day after day, to make their academic haven whole once more. Speeches were made, praises were sung, and gratitude flowed abundantly. It was a chance to give thanks and recognize the collective effort that had brought them to this point.

As the academic year drew to a close, there was a sense of accomplishment and relief emanating throughout the halls of Reedwood University. The faculty looked back at the disruptive and problematic construction repairs with a mix of resignation and endurance. They had endured the inconveniences, the tensions, and the health concerns, all in the hope of a better future.

But it wasn't just the building that had been restored; it was their spirits as well. The challenging experience had taught them not only to persevere but also to appreciate the strength they possessed. They discovered an unwavering resilience that had allowed them to overcome the hurdles before them.

As the summer sun bathed the newly refurbished building in its warmth, there was an air of optimism among the faculty. Their shared experience had bonded them, creating a camaraderie that would endure long after the echoes of construction faded away. They would face whatever challenges lay ahead, secure in the knowledge that their resilience had carried them through the storm.

And so, as the academic year came to a close, the faculty of Reedwood University stood united, knowing that they had weathered the storm and emerged stronger

on the other side. Their determination, perseverance, and newfound sense of resilience would guide them through any future obstacles they may encounter. As they locked the doors of their offices, they looked forward to a well-deserved break, ready to return with renewed vigor and seize whatever awaited them in the next chapter of their academic journey.

The repairs at Reedwood University were more than just a restoration of the physical building; they were a catalyst for personal growth. Dr. Thompson was not the only one who experienced a transformation during the renovation period. The faculty as a whole had gone through a metamorphosis of spirit.

In the aftermath of the repairs, Dr. Thompson began to notice a change in her colleagues. A renewed sense of resilience emanated from each of them. Dr. Miller, once frustrated by the constant noise and dust, became more patient and understanding. He felt a deep connection to his colleagues, as they had all endured the same trials together.

Dr. Morgan, who had previously despised the crowded faculty lounge, now saw it as a symbol of unity and strength. The renovations had turned the space into a place of solace and camaraderie, where faculty members could come together to share their stories and find support.

The faculty lounge became a hub of activity. They organized weekly gatherings where they would take turns sharing their experiences during the renovation period. Each story resonated deeply with the others, creating a tapestry of shared emotions and understanding. The faculty laughed, cried, and offered words of encouragement to one another. They were no longer just colleagues; they were a community brought together by adversity.

The bond among the faculty became so strong that they decided to take their newfound resilience beyond the confines of Reedwood University. They organized a series of motivational talks and workshops for other academic institutions, sharing their journey of overcoming challenges and finding strength in the face of adversity. Their stories inspired countless others who had experienced their own trials and tribulations.

As word spread about the faculty of Reedwood University and their inspiring journey, they were invited to speak at conferences and seminars. They became sought-after speakers, their stories of resilience resonating with audiences around the world. The faculty found themselves traveling to different countries, sharing their experiences and motivating others to embrace their own strength.

Back at Reedwood University, the new academic year began with a renewed sense of purpose. The faculty returned to their roles as educators, armed with a greater understanding of the power of resilience. The students could sense the positive energy radiating from their professors, and they too began to adopt the same mindset of perseverance and determination.

The renovated building became a symbol of triumph for the entire Reedwood community. Students and faculty alike took pride in the scars that adorned

their halls, knowing that they were a testament to their ability to overcome challenges. Even visitors to the university could feel the spirit of resilience that permeated the air, inspiring them to face their own obstacles head-on.

As years went by, the story of Reedwood University and its faculty became an enduring legend. Their tale of resilience and triumph was passed down from generation to generation, inspiring future students and educators to never give up in the face of adversity.

And so, the legacy of Reedwood University lives on, carried in the hearts and minds of all who have been touched by the story of a community that weathered the storm and emerged stronger on the other side. The spirit of resilience continues to guide the university's faculty and students, reminding them that they are capable of overcoming any challenge that may come their way.

-----The End-----

Story2

The relentlessly prolonged, dreary and unpredictable rains, in stark contrast to the weatherman's predictions, persisted far longer than anyone could have anticipated. As a result, the faculty gathered each morning in the atrium, concernedly whispering about cellar flooding and examining maps of the coming day's repairs. Task forces emerged from these conversations, appointed to examine the dire situation, and whole committees formed for the first time to tackle the unending deluge. The ever-present humidity left an unmistakable, permeating odor: a clammy, waterlogged scent that insidiously crept from even the remotest anechoic chamber in the basement to the upstairs textiles lab. The woeful occupants of the Faculty Complex were resigned to undertake arduous courses of action. Thus began the tale of one of the most troublesome periods in the institution's history.

At first, people tried to dismiss the scent out of their ardent sense of willpower, but as time went on, it gradually became all but impossible. Ceiling panels began to wilt and drip, and mold and mildew left dark stains on the walls, eerily resembling the spectral hands of some undiscovered undead spirit. Effie Blythe, the much-loved archivist, had taken to wearing an oilskin slicker as she tirelessly indexed the university's precious medieval manuscripts, her desk cluttered with binders, folders, and wonderfully intricate leather-bound books propped open to support their delicate, aging spines.

The Faculty Complex, designed and constructed in 2010, featured a less-than-adequate waterproofing layer. This significant and alarming oversight had been relegated to the small print of the construction contract, overlooked by an inexperienced Project Manager who—as it later emerged—had been accepting illicit fees from various firms bidding on the work. Despite the University's early success in averting a public scandal, it was now impossible to ignore the all-encompassing problems. Gossip propagated throughout the hallways, and

whispered conversations of frustration and disbelief grew in intensity concerning the extensive damage that had been negligently inflicted.

A now-yellowing copy of the complex blueprints had been unearthed from a forgotten cabinet, their unfurling before the twitchy, anxious faculty reminiscent of a long-overdue revelation, a band-aid being ripped off an old wound. What had once been an orderly arrangement of laboratories, offices, and classrooms, now descended into a labyrinth during repairs. The Complex had transformed into a bewildering network of spaces, twisted by snaking two-by-fours, serpentine copper pipes, and plywood bridges. External experts continuously slathered on tar, sealant, and temporary cladding at remarkable and ever-increasing costs. In order to keep the walls dry, workers employed propane heaters, further adding a faint petroleum scent to the persistent smell of dampness.

Upon noticing the issue, the American Society for the Prevention of Architectural Rot (ASPAR) wasted no time in laying siege with foam-guns and respirator masks. Professors could be seen panicked, knocking persistently on their door, clutching some vital document and pleading to be let into his or her office. The daily routines of the faculty were interrupted, and tensions exponentially increased. Even the formerly beloved cats, once lauded in local news as part of a rodent extermination campaign for their success in curbing a rat infestation in the English palliative literature department, now found themselves skulking at the edges of the loathsome project, meowing pitifully.

The professors, researchers, and administration members were as unique and diverse as the programs that the department housed. The building had originally been conceived as a monument to faculty diversity and unity, in the name of increased academic productivity. The initial hope had been that disparate departments would find valuable collaboration in the chance encounters that the shared premises would provide. What the dean referred to as "scientific interdisciplinary synergies." Sadly, however, these shared premises inevitably led to unexpected consequences, chaotic results, and a series of petty vendettas between departments.

As a result of the ongoing disaster, a grand chamber that had once been set aside for the choir now lay occupied by cluttered buckets and piles of disordered, abandoned toolboxes. Their makeshift meeting space was nothing more than a large closet, which incited the voice department head to protest vehemently the situation, citing the need for "an environment that fostered emotional engagement in order to adequately deliver vocal technique." Her scream of fury echoed through the hallways, demonstrating the potency of her vocal prowess.

The biologist offices, meanwhile, brimmed with boxes of frogs, preserved specimens from an experiment that had enigmatically spiraled out of control. The neuroscientists found themselves sharing a room with the linguists; the organic chemists were unceremoniously billeted with anthropology, and the ancient historians - whose quarters had once itself been a vivacious laboratory devoted to the very sciences they now passionately sought to understand - were unceremo-

niously crammed into all the most incongruous nooks and crannies that could be found strewn throughout the complex.

If the notion of a harmonious team working together existed, it would be far removed from this beleaguered group of individuals. At first glance, the untrained eye might have expected an academic faculty to be a tranquil and serious environment. Alas, this was a woefully incorrect misconception. At any moment, an out-of-place word or a disagreement of ideologies could ignite a series of profound arguments lasting for unending days. Challenges, rebuttals, errant hypotheses, and insults flew around like ill-tempered haymakers, with frosty silences and cold shoulders the inevitable consequence. The mischievous rearrangement of door placards in the night was a common form of sabotage, and on one unforgettable occasion, an irate ethnomusicologist doused a lounge full of potted plants in bleach.

In order to preserve their sanity and departmental dignity, most faculty members opted to remain in their offices, doors firmly closed, their windows showing the tangled complexity of their thoughts through the overflowing jumble of books and folders contained therein. A silent sign language comprised of raised eyebrows and sudden darting glances developed among the neighbors, with each learned member diligently applying these warnings in response to tensions. "Do not, under any circumstances, enter the third-floor washroom while the sociolinguists are arguing," might be one such unspoken admonition.

Over time, as the days turned to weeks, the complexity of the repairs became increasingly tenacious. The art historians, initially pleased with their newly sealed skylight, soon discovered that they could no longer stand the invasive glare. Thus, the chief architect designed an elaborate system of retractable Roman shades personally commissioned from a leading textile designer as a unique solution to the issue.

The Classicists, having suffered through three separate floods, eventually relocated permanently to the Philosophy building. The philosophers, thoroughly unappreciative of their new neighbors, remarked with hushed furor on the uniformed workmen that now traversed the halls en route to an undisclosed job in the basement. "Gnomons," one distressed sophomore muttered, "crossing the River Styx."

The seemingly never-ending work on the Faculty Complex unsurprisingly continued unabated. Consequently, the academic body was subject to innumerable frustrations, delays, and irritations. Yet in this challenging time, the faculty somehow found solace in the knowledge that each work of expression - be it a book, an article, or a symphony - had herself endured a similarly arduous process. As deadlines loomed and dissertations were left unwritten, tempers flared, and resignations, as well as hasty departures for sabbaticals, began to accumulate.

However, as life in the Faculty Complex became increasingly unbearable, the disheartened professors also remembered the importance of the sterner stuff of

which they were once made. In times when cadavers were procured for academic pursuits in ways that were even more arduous and morally challenging, it was the collective memory of these hardships endured that once helped to sustain the faculty. With that source of strength and the infinite promise of better future circumstances in mind, they struggled on together.

Thus, the story concludes with a monument to faculty diversity, which once existed solely to enhance academic productivity, now standing as a stark reminder of the challenges faced when watery mismanagement threatened its very existence. Many still recall those agonizing days, reflecting with a sense of melancholy fondness on those shared experiences which brought them closer together and fostered the discovery of unexpected common interests.

That time was, above all else, an extraordinary period of trenchant disputes, heated challenges, deep introspection and, ultimately, acceptance and endurance - a testament to the unwavering spirit of academic persistence. In hindsight, perhaps it was that difficult, shared experience which first led the classicists to identify a connection between the damp climate and the poetry of Archilochus. It was this same fortitude that enabled a team of engineers to create the first tunable membrane which resolved the glare problem while also harmonizing with the dulcet tones of the choir.

Finally, it was the enduring strength of the faculty, who, though never entirely comfortable, refused to give up hope in the face of adversity. And so, from the depths of the wet archives and shared turmoil, the seeds of collaboration and innovation thrived.

-----The End-----

Story3

The old tower stood alone at the end of the campus, isolated from the sleek modernist buildings that made up the rest. The brick facade and arched windows were throwbacks to the glory days of finger-wave haircuts and double-breasted suits, but its age showed in the failing plumbing and sagging floors.

Professor James Grey sighed at the Victorian beauty as he unlocked his office door one rainy Monday morning. Just inside, a large metal bucket sat under a jagged crack in the ceiling that was dripping a steady stream of murky water into its rim. Professor Grey set down the stack of ungraded papers he was carrying and called facilities again. The voicemail box was already full, just like the previous week day and the days before. This ongoing issue infuriated Professor Grey as he had called multiple times over the past several weeks with no response or solution.

The university's apparent apathy towards the deteriorating conditions of the tower amplified his annoyance. After dedicating over two decades of his life to this institution, the neglect of the old tower felt like a betrayal of the ideals that had drawn him to academia. He contemplated organizing a protest with other faculty members to raise awareness about the failing infrastructure in

hopes of eliciting action rather than empty promises from the administration. After making a few phone calls, he managed to gather a group of like-minded professors the English and History departments who shared his concerns over the neglect of the old tower. They spent several hours over the next few days meticulously planning and preparing to ensure their message would be heard clearly by the administration.

Professor Grey slowly climbed the four flights of creaking stairs that led to his attic office on the top floor, each step threatening to give out under his weight. The staircases were made of an ancient wood that protested with every movement as he climbed towards his office. His frail body and advancing age made the hike up the stairs a dangerous endeavor each morning he came into work. Most of the offices were empty over the summer, but he could hear muffled cursing coming from Dr. Lisa Hart's makeshift laboratory on the second floor.

Dr. Hart had been working as a postdoctoral researcher developing a new chemical technique for identifying trace amounts of toxins. She was attempting to extract specific toxic molecules to develop antidotes in case of chemical spills or attacks. Her highly sensitive work was frequently disrupted by the failing infrastructure, with leaks and spills destroying months of labor. However, her passion for research to improve society led her to persevere in the face of many obstacles. "Pipe leak again?" he asked, poking his head into her open door. She looked up from a bench covered in disassembled lab equipment and nodded grimly. After commiserating over the latest infrastructure failure, Professor Grey invited Dr. Hart to join their protest efforts. She eagerly agreed, hoping to draw attention to the adverse impact the building conditions had on critical research.

"I've been here since five this morning mopping up. And of course it happens the week I have four time-sensitive experiments running." Dr. Hart sighed. "I give up. At this point, I just expect a new disaster every time I unlock the door." The university had been attempting to renovate parts of the tower for the past two years, but their efforts seemed only to lead to new issues arising. The contractors were clearly cutting corners instead of aligning with building standards and specifications,

Entire sections of the plumbing system had been replaced, yet pipes still burst without warning. The roof was patched and tarred over and over, though water still found its way into offices and stairwells. Rumors of asbestos and outdated wiring abounded. Students and faculty alike dreaded each new repair, wondering what havoc it might wreak and how long it might drag on. The process seemed an endless cycle of band-aid fixes instead of substantive improvements and repairs.

Professor Grey continued up the stairs to the top floor attic that housed his office. The narrow room had sloping walls and a lone arched window overlooking the campus. Three of the light fixtures had been non-functional for weeks, and his allergies flared up each time the wind blew in from outside. He glanced at the

exposed wooden beams above his head, noting new cracks that hadn't been there yesterday.

The professor had spent over 30 years in this office, having earned his position as a young scholar newly graduated with a doctorate in English literature. Like the building, his field of study was antiquated compared to the technical fields emphasized today in this science and technology era. However, he remained devoted to studying and teaching the classics, striving to demonstrate their timeless relevance and value to society. His was an expertise that sought to cultivate wisdom and ponder ideas that spanned generations.

He shuffled the stack of papers on his desk and rifled through to find where he had left off, just as a loud crashing sound echoed down the hallway, followed by yelling and the roar of heavy machinery starting up again. The disturbances disrupted his concentration, and he let out an exasperated sigh. The repairs never seemed to improve the status and conditions of the building. The stall tactics of the contractors and administration drove the professors and students of the tower to utter frustration. His eyes drifted to gaze out the arched window, observing the students walking below on their way to midmorning classes. Their lively chatter and laughter drifted up to him, reminding Professor Grey of his own college days when he had studied under his mentor in this very same office.

His mentor had instilled in him a deep appreciation for literature and passion for education transcended the challenges of the setting. Professor Grey was determined to maintain that same persevering spirit with his own students. He refused to allow the negligence and apathy of others to diminish his passion for teaching and advocacy. The protest continued late into the evening, reminding administration of the gravity of the situation and the steadfast dedication of faculty members of the old tower.

He took a deep breath and resumed his seat, picking up the papers once more. The noises raged on around him, but he focused his attention on the analysis in front of him, red pen scribbling comments and suggestions in the margins. For a moment, all faded away except the thoughts and ideas on the page. His calling had always been to open minds, not bemoan circumstances beyond his control.

The stack of papers grew smaller as the hours passed. Dusk fell softly outside the great arched window, the chatter of students now replaced by the chirping of crickets. The repairs had ceased for the day, leaving an unnatural silence in their absence. As Professor Grey made his way out of the old tower, he thought back to how the building had inspired generations of students and faculty alike throughout the years, despite its aging structure. Though many had complained about its deteriorating facade and outdated architecture, the tower held a sense of nostalgia that connected the present to the glory days of the past.

Its crumbling halls had witnessed the transformation of young minds, shaped by those devoted to cultivating wisdom and intellectual curiosity. Though the university claimed to prioritize progress, their actions showed a lack of care

for the foundation on which their institution had been built. However, as long as there were still devoted professors fueling student minds with passion for knowledge within its walls, the old tower would stand as a monument to the timeless ideals of academia.

Though the future was uncertain, that flicker of hope remained as steadfast as the old tower itself. The professor smiled softly to himself as he locked up for the night, leaving the remaining papers ready on his desk awaiting the dawn and the continuation of his lifelong mission.

-----The End-----

Story4

Between the exterior wall and the Sheetrock, a waterproofing layer was missing. The builders, in their defense, said that the layer had simply been forgotten about, not left out in an intentional move to save money. The building was faculty housing, occupied only by professors and their families. All but one professor were untenured. Half had kids under ten.

The layer had been found to be missing during a city inspection a decade ago. Repairs were put off for nine years. The school, as both employer and landlord, cited extreme busyness, and pointed out that, despite the missing barrier, no actual apartment floods had occurred. Year ten there was a global pandemic, but year ten was also the end of the remediation period, so construction had to start. The contractor hosted a virtual meeting to explain the many phases of the process. The slide show had several typos. "Demolition became "demonition; no apartment number was listed correctly. How disruptive would all this be, the dance professor asked, and the cherub-faced blond contractor's spokesman answered politely, "Very much so, ma'am. Then the chemistry professor chimed in about particulates. If the entire brick façade was being torn off, what was being done about air-quality control? The chemistry professor had small children. Small children had small lungs. The blond man said that they would tape over everyone's windows. They would tape over the vents of everyone's A.C.s. "So, no A.C.s or windows? another professor asked. "All through summer, no opening windows or running A.C.s? This professor, who taught biology and kept on the building's rooftop a colony of honeybees, was not known to repeat himself. The blond man said that that was correct. And that the rooftop would be closed to accommodate the rigging, so the bee colony would have to be moved.

To better address the concerns of the tenants, a second virtual meeting was called, and predictably it went much worse.

The third virtual meeting was cancelled, and, a day later, scaffolding went up. Spaghetti-like ropes encased the building, and men in orange vests carrying hammer drills appeared on skinny platform lifts. Windows were covered with a neon-blue film that turned every room into an aquarium and gave tenants headaches. "No one's complained about the blue film before, the contractor said,

though he then admitted to never having worked on an occupied building before. Clear film was procured four days later, the windows retaped. The contractor did boast about having an on-site hygienist, a woman who was copied on e-mails but whom no one had met.

For three weeks, the noise level was terrible, from nine to five, Monday through Friday, with no pause. The new writing professor was trying to finish a novel but could only write things like "So this is what it must feel like to live inside a tooth that a dentist is trying to drill. The tooth occupied her thoughts nightly. She hadn't gone to the dentist in years. Red dust coated the window film; plumes of smoke were seen. The religion professor brought up the plumes, how, from her red-tinted window, they seemed cloudlike even. The contractor replied immediately, copying the hygienist, to clarify that what the professor saw was not a plume or anything close to a cloud but a puff of smoke being aggrandized by the wind.

Each morning, there was an e-mail update explaining which units would be most directly affected that day, though the apartment numbers were still incorrect. So, to figure out if you were truly going to be affected, you had to watch for where the huge mechanical pulley on the roof was dropping lifts. Glancing up at the building from the outside, the ceramics professor was reminded of his childhood, and that unwinnable arcade game with a bin of plush toys and a slippery claw. He was on the corner waiting for Mister Softee. He was waiting for Mister Softee because his three boys, who were inside, had told him to text them when the truck was in sight.

The technical term for what was missing was flashing—an embedded sheet of metal that prevents moisture from penetrating a building's walls. Flashing is particularly important at junctions, around windows, vent pipes, etc. No one thought anymore of the word's other meanings—committing indecent exposure, for example, running buck naked across a green field in a Superman cape, as the six-year-old son of the dance professor had done during his first soccer game.

Inclement weather set in one weekend, a hurricane muscling through from the south. Rain fell for three days and nights, and the history professor, whose apartment was right below the pulley, said it sounded as if it were raining within the walls. Could there be a leak? He sent the company an audio clip. The company responded a minute later. Leaks were impossible. They had sealed all the leaks because that was what they were here to do. Below the history professor lived a math professor, who all weekend had been collecting the water that had funnelled into her office through the ceiling. She used a one-gallon bucket, and she'd emptied the bucket into the bathtub five times. The math professor was married to the East Asian Studies professor. Not that ironically, the former was Asian and the latter white. Between gallons three and four, the former had drafted an angry e-mail to the school, but then stared at her unnuanced message. She worried about being the squeaky wheel, when she and her husband had upcoming third-year reviews. Still, she asked if he could rewrite and send the e-mail, given both his nuance skills and the fact that the administration

might take him more seriously. That would be taking advantage of his privilege, he thought, and shook his head, but encouraged her to send the e-mail, since she should feel empowered to and he was never going to stand in her way. A quarrel about feminism followed. No e-mail was sent. Over text, some tenants hatched a plan. They would implore the one tenured resident—an economics professor—to declare war by sending the e-mail and hiring a lawyer who would then launch the war by suing the school. But the economics professor was away. He'd left for Crete at the start of the construction, on a private jet owned by one of his friends. Within the building, the audio clip went viral and was forwarded anonymously to the project's architect. The architect soon replied in an e-mail about how a pulley system of that weight might have shifted the building's foundation, creating fractures, but this problem was, unfortunately, beyond the company's scope. They dealt only with façades. Another company did foundations.

The next weekend, another storm front came through. Seven gallons, the math professor counted. In the history professor's bedroom, a paint bubble, the height and width of a man, appeared on the wall overnight. He poked the bubble, afraid that it might actually be a person, like his department chair, and was sprayed, drenched, in brown water. The professors lamented in the laundry room. What kind of collective e-mail to send, and in what tone? A seven-hundred-word one was drafted, with bulleted questions for further discussion. The e-mail was edited down to three hundred words, then ballooned again to a thousand.

"We must withhold rent, the ethics professor said—a thought that gave the non-activist professors palpitations.

The walls of the water-filled units now felt spongy, and eventually a two-hundred-word e-mail was sent, signed by all the untenured professors, and ending with the sentence "We demand immediate action. Within an hour, a fit young man arrived and handed everyone he met a business card. The card said that he was the vice-president of the company. The man noted the places where water was still seeping in. He said that there would likely be mold growth, and, should the mold be the color of soot, coal, or volcanic ash, they would need to call in the hygienist to culture it. Not all strains are toxic, he informed them. Some were perfectly O.K. In addition, he'd gone up to the roof and found no visible faults around the pulley system, so perhaps the leak was a preëxisting condition that had suddenly, coincidentally, got worse. "Things like this do happen, he insisted, and added that, once the scaffolding was removed, the foundation would naturally rise up, against gravity, to its previous position. Then he tipped his hard hat at the professors and wished them a good day. So construction went on unimpeded, and more storms came through, and more gallons were collected. Spores grew in the wet areas, none whose colors were quite right to be cultured. Rent was paid reliably; no more complaints were filed. In time, the professors all arrived at the same conclusion. Was the leak really that bad? On good days, it sounded like living next to a waterfall. Push through it, the way you did in grad school; then, once you get tenure, you can

fly to Crete.

-----The End-----